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FUNDAMENTALS OF MANAGEMENT AND ORGANIZATIONAL BEHAVIOR

Week 12 – Managing Groups and Teams

MNT 215 – Summer 2026

Suliman S. Olayan School of Business | American University of Beirut



Slides partly adapted from Robbins, S. P., Coulter, M. A. & Long, L. K. (2024). Management (16th Global Edition).

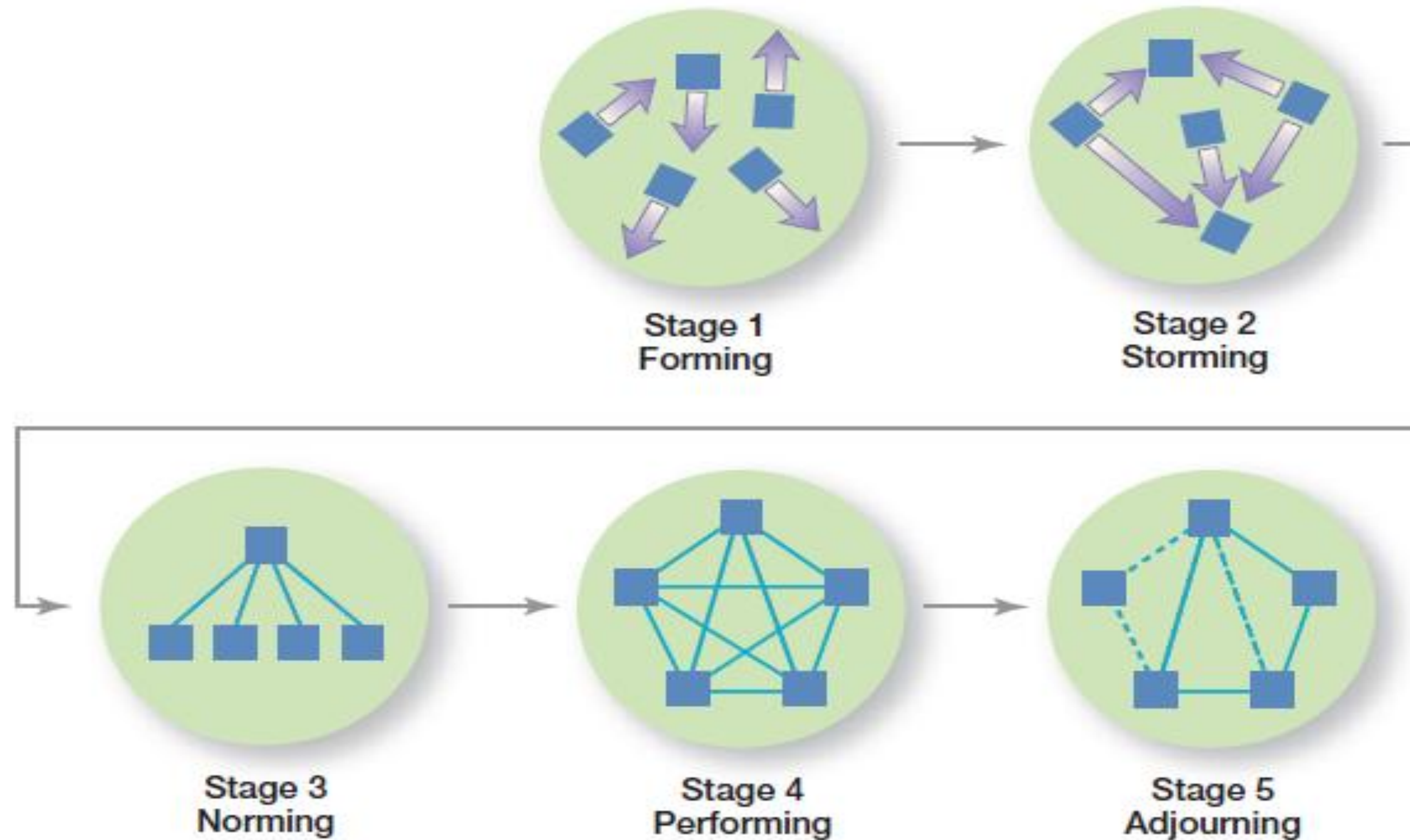


WHAT IS A GROUP?

- **Group:** two or more interacting and interdependent individuals who come together to achieve specific goals
- Formal groups
- Informal groups



STAGES OF GROUP DEVELOPMENT



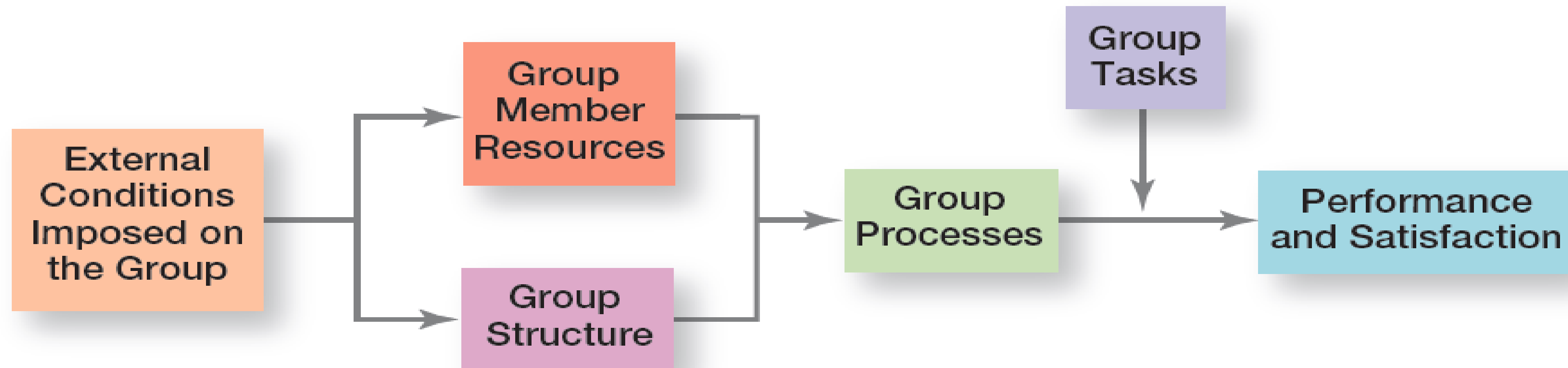


STAGES OF GROUP DEVELOPMENT: SOME LIMITS

- **Assumption:** the group becomes more effective as it progresses through the first four stages
- **Problems:**
 - Not always true – group behavior is more complex
 - The process is not always linear
 - Several stages may occur simultaneously
 - Groups may regress
 - Some conflict conducive to high performance
 - Ignores the organizational context (culture, structure, leadership, resources, etc.)



GROUP PERFORMANCE/SATISFACTION MODEL





EXTERNAL CONDITIONS IMPOSED ON THE GROUP

- External conditions include:
 - Organization's strategy
 - Authority relationships
 - Formal rules and regulations
 - Availability of resources
 - Employee selection criteria



GROUP MEMBER RESOURCES

- Knowledge
- Abilities
- Skills
- Personality traits



GROUP STRUCTURE (1 OF 2)

- **Role:** behavior patterns expected of someone occupying a given position in a social unit
- **Norms:** standards or expectations that are accepted and shared by a group's members



GROUP STRUCTURE (2 OF 2)

- Status systems:
 - **Status:** a prestige grading, position, or rank within a group
- Group size:
 - **Social loafing:** the tendency for individuals to expend less effort when working collectively than when working individually
- **Group cohesiveness:** the degree to which group members are attracted to one another and share the group's goals



GROUP COHESIVENESS AND PRODUCTIVITY

		Cohesiveness	
		High	Low
Alignment of Group and Organizational Goals	High	Strong Increase in Productivity	Moderate Increase in Productivity
	Low	Decrease in Productivity	No Significant Effect on Productivity



GROUP PROCESSES: CONFLICT MANAGEMENT

- **Conflict:** perceived incompatible differences that result in interference or opposition
 - **Traditional view of conflict:** the view that all conflict is bad and must be avoided
 - **Human relations view of conflict:** the view that conflict is a natural and inevitable outcome in any group

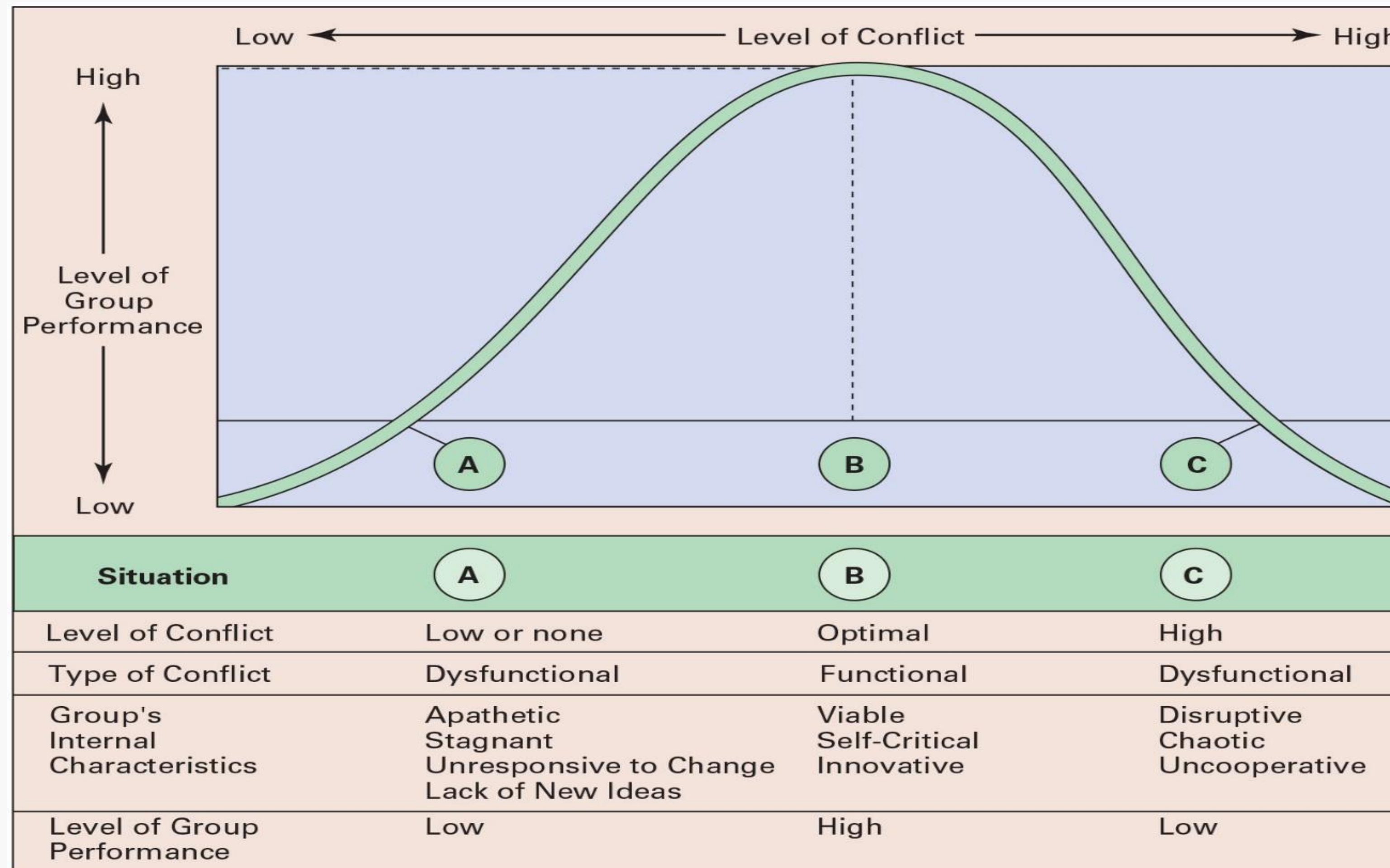


INTERACTIONIST VIEW OF CONFLICT

- **Interactionist view of conflict:** the view that some conflict is necessary for a group to perform effectively
 - **Functional conflicts:** conflicts that support a group's goals and improve its performance
 - **Dysfunctional conflicts:** conflicts that prevent a group from achieving its goals



CONFLICT AND GROUP PERFORMANCE





TYPES OF CONFLICT

- **Task conflict:** conflict over content and goals of the work
- **Relationship conflict:** conflict based on interpersonal relationships
- **Process conflict:** conflict over how work gets done

HOW TO RESOLVE CONFLICTS?

- Voting as a procedure
- Compromise or consensus to reach agreement
- Discussion or debate of ideas and opinions
- Open communication: the level of affect or emotion in team discussions
- Specific solutions for fixing or responding to specific problems
- Avoidance or ignoring of conflict by the team
- Rotation of responsibilities: procedures for allocating responsibilities within the team



TYPE OF CONFLICT AND RESOLUTION

Type of conflict	Increased performance and satisfaction
Task	Use discussion/debate and open communication to reach compromise/consensus
Relation	Use discussion/debate and specific solutions to avoid/ignore conflicts [decreased satisfaction]
Procedure	discussion/debate and compromise/consensus to establish rotating responsibilities



GROUP TASKS

- It's the **complexity** and **interdependence** of tasks that influence a group's effectiveness.



THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN GROUPS AND TEAMS

- **Work teams:** groups whose members work intensely on a specific, common goal using their positive synergy, individual and mutual accountability, and complementary skills
- **Work groups:** Work groups interact primarily to share information and to make decisions to help each member do their job more efficiently and effectively

GROUPS VERSUS TEAMS

Work Teams

Leadership role is shared
Accountable to self and team
Team creates specific purpose

Work is done collectively
Meetings characterized by open-ended discussion and collaborative problem-solving
Performance is measured directly by evaluating collective work output
Work is decided upon and done together
Can be quickly assembled, deployed, refocused, and disbanded

Work Groups

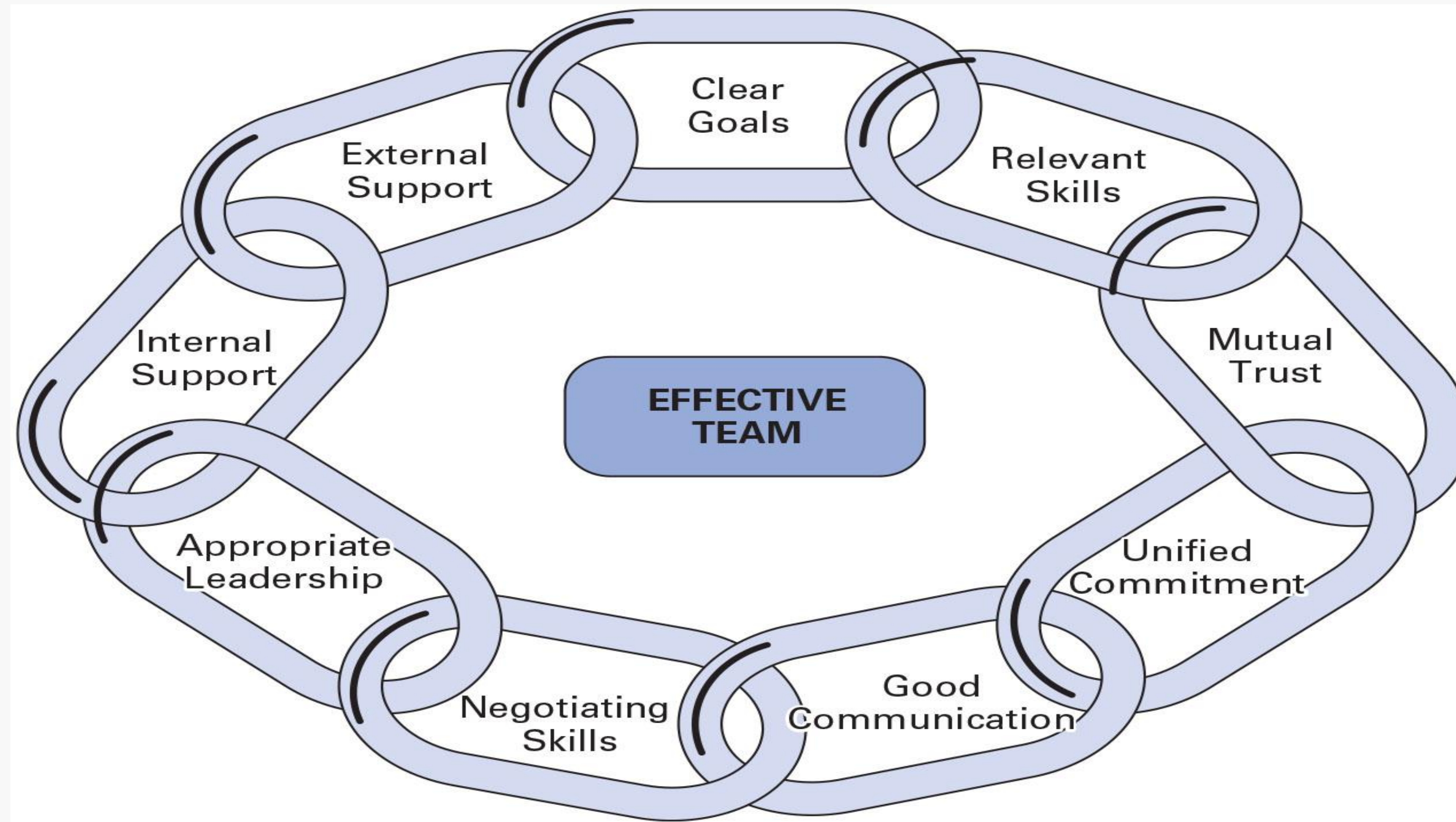
One leader clearly in charge
Accountable only to self
Purpose is same as broader organizational purpose
Work is done individually
Meetings characterized by efficiency; no collaboration or open-ended discussion
Performance is measured indirectly according to its influence on others
Work is decided upon by group leader and delegated to individual group members
blank



What determines a team's effectiveness?



CHARACTERISTICS OF EFFECTIVE TEAMS





BUT ALSO: TEAM PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY

- “*a shared belief that the team is safe for interpersonal risk taking*” (Edmonson, 1999, p. 354)
- It differs from group cohesiveness as cohesiveness can reduce willingness to disagree with others (e.g., groupthink, Janis, 1982)
- Team **psychological safety** is associated with learning behavior (e.g., seeking feedback, sharing information, asking for help, speaking up, etc.) and individual and team performance (Edmonson, 1999; Edmonson & Bransby, 2023)
- Example of **Google Aristotle Project**.



TEAM PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY

Scale

1. If you make a mistake on this team, it is often held against you. (R)
2. Members of this team are able to bring up problems and tough issues.
3. People on this team sometimes reject others for being different. (R)
4. It is safe to take a risk on this team.
5. It is difficult to ask other members of this team for help. (R)
6. No one on this team would deliberately act in a way that undermines my efforts.
7. Working with members of this team, my unique skills and talents are valued and utilized.

HOW TO FOSTER TEAM PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY?

- Care about team members as individuals
- Actively solicit questions
- Offer employees multiple ways to share their thoughts
- Show that you value and appreciate ideas
- Promote positive dialogue and discussion
- Be specific in your information, expectations, and commitments
- Explain the reasons for change
- Acknowledge your mistakes

THANK YOU



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